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Exercises for Syntax

Syntax 1: Grammatical Categories and Word Classes

1. Identify the meaning or function of the underlined definite/indefinite article in each of the following.

Example: It was a week after Christmas

Answer: a = 'one'

(a) The wind is whistling around the house.

(b) The door flew open.

(c) The gray cat from next door ran into the house.

(d) A cat is trapped in the cellar.

(e) Yesterday I saw a cat. The cat was wearing a collar.

(f) I like a long-haired cat.

(g) A cat makes a good companion.

(h) The "Puss" I know lives across the street.

2. Identify the meaning or function of the present tense in each of the following sentences.

Example: The chemical composition of water is H2O.

Answer: timeless statement

(a) Still waters run deep.

(b) Classes end November 30.

(c) Janet bites her nails.

(d) I think he was wrong.

(e) Anna Karenina commits suicide.

(f) Yesterday, I'm in a store and it's held up.

(g) The earth revolves around the sun.

(h) We hear that you are going to be a grandparent soon.

(i) The early bird catches the worm.

(j) I know the answer.

(k) Napier passes the ball to Jones.

(l) Phyllis teaches elementary school.

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3. Discuss what each of the following sentences shows concerning the formal expression of the passive.

Example: The balloons were released.

Answer: agentless be-passive

(a) The kite got tangled in the tree.

(b) The dried mud will brush off.

(c) Your shoes need polishing.

(d) You should brace yourself for the worst.

(e) That is being taken care of.

(f) The dog became confused by the loud noises.

4. Discuss what each of the following sentences shows concerning the formal expression of the subjunctive.

Example: Heaven preserve us.

Answer: inflected subjunctive in main clause

(a) I suggest that she take another course.

(b) If I were going, I could take you.

(c) I was thinking of asking you to help.

(d) This might do the trick.

(e) The news is probably bad.

(f) You're right, I'm sure.

Internal use only

5. Identify the grammatical distinction exemplified by the underlined word or phrase and explain its meaning.

Example: person: <u>You</u> never can tell.
Answer: 2nd person used for generic purposes

(a) case:	The <u>building's</u> collapse was impressive.
(b) tense:	The moon <u>circles</u> the earth.
(c) aspect:	We <u>have argued</u> since we were children.
(d) tense:	My parents <u>are going to visit</u> next weekend.
(e) definiteness:	I wonder where <u>the</u> remote control is.
(f) number:	<u>Rattlesnakes</u> live in the desert.
(g) gender:	Who is <u>it</u> at the door?
(h) voice:	The dog's tail <u>got caught</u> in the door.
(i) tense:	All's well that <u>ends</u> well.
(j) case:	You should have given <u>Jack</u> the opportunity to answer.
(k) person:	She let <u>me</u> copy her class notes.

6. Identify the word class of up in each of the following.

(a) Your time is up.

(b) She's in an up mood.

(c) He upped the ante.

(d) The balloons rose up into the sky.

(e) The dog tore up the slipper.

(f) Life is full of ups and downs.

(g) They live just up the street from us.

7. Identify the word class of down in each of the following.

(a) Alex is feeling rather down today.

(b) Would you write your address down for me?

(c) On a dare, he downed the whole beer.

(d) That was a first down, wasn't it?

(e) The computers are down today.

(f) He ran down the stairs.

(g) He looked down because he was embarrassed.

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Syntax 2: Phrases

1. Label the phrasal category of each underlined phrase. Then name its function.

Example: he gave the dog a hesitant, reassuring pat.
Answer: Category: NP: Function: iO

(a) Your article gave readers a glimpse of the truth.

(b) I relied upon knowledge, imagination, observation, and visual memory.

(c) Kids' shoes are a quickly expanding market.

(d) For many years I taught an introductory theology course for undergraduates.

(e) In a sense it was similar to e-mail today.

(f) His colleagues all thought him quite mad.

(g) Praise even came from the other side of the world.

(h) We're more fixated on the radiant glow that moms-to-be exude.

(i) It taught me 16-hour days and multitasking.

(j) It was in an advanced state of disrepair, every window broken.

(k) I chose him as a subject of my test.

(l) They sounded hauntingly familiar to me.

(m) Relativity became the paradigm of the atomic age.

(n) Mary was leaning over on her elbow.

(o) All of the rest of the good-paying jobs are gone.

(p) The legacy built by the baby boomers is in danger.

2. Identify the verb type in each sentence.

(a) Those useful items are in very high demand.

(b) She followed the detailed instructions on the back of the box.

(c) We put the books with torn pages under the counter.

(d) The doctor administered the shot to the crying child.

(e) The students concentrated on the assignment for the next day's class.

(f) My aunt is quite allergic to the roses in the garden.

(g) Those other people are very distantly related to us.

(h) We went to our relatives' cabin in the mountains.

(i) The manager discounted the very slightly damaged goods.

(j) They pushed the table right up against the back wall.

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3. Determine the sentence pattern (clause structure) for each sentence given below.

1. The coach will offer free tennis lessons today at noon.

   ……

2. On Friday the judge gave the thief a five-year sentence.

   ……

3. I will be at the meeting tonight.

   ……

4. Most women consider Snodgrass a handsome man.

   ……

5. Your approval would be nice.

   ……

6. Masie and I talked on the telephone for four hours.

   ……

7. The pie in the over smells delicious.

   ……

8. Jackson was the most competent man in the company.

   ……

9. That young man will probably become a famous movie star.

   ……

10. Jim found your remarks outrageous.

    ……

11. Ethan gives us piano lessons each Friday.

    ……

12. An inner circle of politicians made Matthews treasurer of the campaign.

    ……

13. Children are often good judges of character.

    ……

14. The farmer at the roadside stand gave me an extra ear of corn.

    ……

15. We felt at home during our visit.

    ……

16. The child behaved horribly in the store.

    ……

17. On his last trip to Russia in the spring, Hilda finally felt comfortable.

    ……

18. In another life I must have been a dancer.

    ……

19. Upon his return, the people elected Jasper king of the entire country.

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20. My brother showed me the stream behind the wooded area.

……

21. You are very quiet today.

……

22. The personality test found Jenkins unsuitable for the position.

……

23. After much deliberation, Millie bought the biggest car on the lot.

……

24. Later, Smithers became the most important person in his life.

……

25. The poor sailor was at sea for a year.

……

26. Under most circumstances, we would be happy with your work.

……

27. The professor considered the student a genius at mathematics.

……

28. Ulcers give people pain.

……

29. He waited in the rain for an hour.

……

30. During my teen years, I grew tall.

……

31. On the Fourth of July, people in my neighborhood meet at the park for a picnic.

……

32. He bought me a large jade pin for my birthday this year.

……

33. The squadron found the enemy formidable.

……

34. Since last August I have been a member of that club.

……

35. Out of everyone in the room, Susan is by far the laziest.

……

36. The rescue workers called George a hero for his actions.

……

37. The young woman defiantly put her books on the table.

……

38. The cornbread tasted like mush.

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39. Until 3 p.m. Uncle George will be at the bank.

……

40. At graduation, Joe will officially become a pilot.

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Syntax 3: Types of clauses

1. Identify the type and function of each nonfinite clause.

Example: I plan to make some Mint Juleps.

Answer: to make some Mint Juleps

Type: *to*-infinitive

Function: dO

(a) There was still one last task for him to achieve.

(b) Anderson and his son had often talked about hiking to Shoshone Lake.

(c) We've had to hire people to answer the phones.

(d) My parents asked me where to eat lunch.

(e) The patient had earlier denied having been bitten or scratched by a cat.

(f) A bank employee loudly turned down her application to open an account.

(g) Worried about his future, he went to college.

(h) Judging from the online photos, the place looked adorable.

(i) He asked her what made her think she could paint.

(j) Yet he remained committed to Irish republicanism.

(k) We think that's not the best idea, to raffle off guns.

(l) Half the money spent on a political campaign is wasted.

(m) Having been founded by the Saracens in the ninth century, Nettuno still attracts tourists.

(n) Consumed by a sudden curiosity, Buridan follows.

(o) It's hard to know where to draw the line.

Internal use only

2. Identify the function of the italicized nonfinite clause in each sentence.

(a) He is anxious *to be getting away.*

(b) I was surprised at *Sid's criticizing my work.*

(c) *For them to lose their son* was a great tragedy.

(d) Do we have the money *to buy that car*?

(e) We were pleased *to be seeing our old friends*.

(f) It is very tedious *writing papers*.

(g) He has been warned about *taking on that job*.

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(h) I will write the manager *to get my money back*.

(i) Where is the best place *to buy fish*?

(j) We regretted his decision *to leave university*.

(k) We were not able *to get away until now*.

(l) Anyone *not registered in this course* must leave.

(m) *To tell you the truth*, I don't know.

(n) He is the person *wanting to see you*.

(o) *Wanting to see him*, I visited his office.

3. Bracket the that-clause in each of the following and identify its function (Su, sC, dO, comp of A, comp of NP, or eSu).

(a) The employee complaint that triggered the investigation was retracted.

(b) That he is gone seems unnatural.

(c) My guess is that he has a plan.

(d) It was apparent that the waiters know the kitchen and the wine list.

(e) She is confident that the Sioux will one day own the Black Hills again.

(f) We know it's created a tremendous amount of fear.

(g) We were just happy he didn't get in.

(h) The news that others are finding similar data is extremely exciting.

(i) The blast of heat told her that the lightning had struck nearby.

(j) It was outrageous that they e-mailed those things here.

Internal use only

4. Identify the nominal and adverbial clauses in the following sentences.

(a) That Nestor made that mistake is rather worrying.

(b) It is rather unlikely that he will propose to her soon.

(c) I hope they will visit me when I am in hospital.

(d) Claude thinks that Stan and Louise would make a nice couple.

(e) My brother said that the man became a millionaire before he reached the age of thirty.

(f) The manager locked the safe because he was concerned that someone might enter the office.

(g) Although the economy is improving, it is not clear that we will see growth this year.

(h) His opinion is that you should take another course after you have completed this one.

(i) Unfortunately, we can't have our picnic if it rains tomorrow.

(j) He said he knew before he had completed the deal that he would be cheated.

(k) It is obvious to everyone that he has been telling the prosecutors lies.

(l) Can the absurd rumor that he will resign be true?

(m) Did he tell the premier that he shouldn't be nervous about the disclosures?

(n) Could the professor have said that the essay by Swift was ironic?

(o) He was upset by the announcement that the plane would be delayed.

(p) I will explain it to him that honest politicians are a rarity.

(q) Sherrill spread the news around the department that Sarah likes tofu.

(r) The owner said that you should use extreme caution when approaching the dog.

5. Identify the non finite in each sentence and state the functions.

(a) Williams continued driving to the corner.

(b) Mr. Shapiro clearly wants to be running this defense team.

(c) Julie admits having stolen her father's money.

(d) Having been elected as a champion of the "forgotten middle class", Clinton will immediately bump up against unpleasant realities.

(e) I don't recall having asked for you, Peter!

(f) One of them even reported his having been seen off the coast of the British Zone on a red yacht.

(g) I much preferred to be thought of as a stylish dowager.

(h) He'd never before heard her say anything remotely like okey-dokey.

(i) All the birds seem to have disappeared from the city.

(j) New York City's budget crisis appeared to have been settled.

(k) The young star wanted to strike out on his own.

(l) Removed from the ocean, Sarbin's slick skin would quickly dry out and crack.

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Syntax 4: Types of sentences

1. Some of the following word groups are fragments while others are simple sentences. Revise any fragment to make a complete sentence. If the word group is a simple sentence, write "correct". No capital letters or end punctuation marks have been used. Use subject-predicate units and complete thoughts to determine your answers.

1. after the tornado struck the small town

……

2. please read the chapter on sentence analysis

……

3. they would like to collect money for the charity

……

4. because you know that I dislike peanut butter

……

5. the older man walking down the stairs

……

6. whether we go to the zoo on Sunday or not

……

7. the new idea created a buzz of excitement

……

8. for example, the public's interest in reality television

……

9. does that tree ever grow pinecones

……

10. as the actress finished reading her monologue

……

11. please put the newspapers into the recycling bin

……

12. when we drove to the new neighborhood

……

13. the doctor advising the patient

……

14. have you seen the new movie about the *Titanic*

……

15. if the powder turns red

……

16. before the sun rises

……

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17. the people giving Tom a graduation party

……

18. she rarely speaks to anyone

……

19. while the cake was baking

……

20. on the table by the old red chair

……

21. when the telephone rang

……

22. can you see the harbor from this window

……

23. students who study in the library

……

24. the picture in the gold frame

……

25. the baby resting in my arms

……

26. although the blue team was ahead

……

27. after we reached the crest of the hill

……

28. the earthquake shook the house for at least five seconds

……

29. whatever you decide

……

30. hand me the sports section please

……

internal use only

2. The following sentences are made up of two independent clauses with one or more dependent clauses. You are to identify the clauses telling what kind each is. The choices are independent clause, noun clause, adjective clause or adverb clause.

1. John went to school, but James remained at home because he had a sore throat.
2. If he changes his mind, we shall know for sure that Joe has learned his lesson, but only time will tell.
3. Those clouds promise rain; we should hurry before we get caught in a flash flood.
4. Here is the money that I owe you, and I am happy to be free of debt.
5. Were you ever in a storm that was full of lightning, or don't you recall?

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6. Since we had gone only a mile from camp, we could return before dark, and we would not become lost.
7. After the tornado had hit, my house was gone, but my neighbor's house was not touched.
8. Mary heard the frightening noise again, and the sound was one that would frighten the bravest of people.
9. The route can be changed, but I know several people who will not like the change.
10. Dr. Mathews did what could be done, but it simply was not enough to save his life.
11. We enlarged our house, and after we had finished the work, we moved to Hawaii and never returned.
12. The vacation should be restful, but many people take vacations that are never restful.
13. James said that will be enough, and everyone agreed.
14. Dad went fishing, but Mom stayed home because she wanted to be there when Terri arrived.
15. Rulon steered the jeep down the muddy road to the camp site, and then he discovered that it was the wrong road.
16. I've just learned that our vacation plans must be changed; as a result, we'll leave later in the month.
17. Older television sets had tubes; the newest models, which take less space, are digital televisions.
18. My Uncle Al drove a snow-removal truck, and when there was a big snow storm, he would be called to work at any time.
19. If you are an election judge, you distribute the ballots, and you count them after the polls close.
20. Many monuments are found around the White House, and foreign leaders who come to Washington often visit them.
21. The doctor told us how we could revive a heart-attack victim, and she demonstrated on a dummy, me.
22. Jeff tried the new dance steps that had been demonstrated, and he mastered them quickly.
23. The bola is a rope which is used to catch animals; it has weights on the end of it.
24. Since he was entrusted with the secret, Fred became very serious, and he was no longer a practical joker.
25. People need to be able to share their fears, frustrations, and joys, so it's important for us to develop a network of people we can share our feelings with.

Internal use only

3. The following sentences are either a simple sentence, a compound sentence, a complex sentence or a compound/complex sentence. Identify the sentences telling what kind each is.

1. Jim and his friend Ryan had planned to return to Canada.
2. Although he searched everywhere, Curtis could find no trace of his shoes.
3. Alaina wrote an original poem, and her mother corrected her spelling.
4. The real story is that he was injured while he was hiking.
5. None of the other jurors asked me to change my mind.
6. Barbara and Jeanne whispered and giggled all night.
7. That he is my cousin cannot be denied.

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8. The boy who is speaking is my brother, and he will be staying with us.
9. I know you don't like him, but that doesn't matter.
10. The training rooms of these college athletes smell of grease and gasoline.
11. Their tools are screwdrivers and spanners rather than basketballs and footballs.
12. his new brand of college athlete is involved in the sport of auto racing.
13. Most of the students are engineering majors, and they devote every minute of their spare time to their sport.
14. Although the sport is new, it has already attracted six collegiate teams in the Southeast.
15. The students work on special cars designed for their sport.
16. The cars are called Legends cars, models of Fords and Chevys from 1932 to 1934, and they are refitted by the students with 1200 cc motorcycle engines.
17. Although their usual speed ranges from 50 to 90 miles an hour, Legends cars can move up to 100 miles an hour on a straightaway.
18. The Saturday morning races of the competing teams have attracted as many as 3,500 fans, but the students concede they are no threat to the nation's fastest growing sport of stock car racing.
19. The house was destroyed in the fire, but the whole family was saved.
20. Walking through the wood, he saw a fox that was following him.
21. If I do not get this job, I will start a business.
22. He said that he was so disappointed that he would not try again.
23. The men who rule the world with their pens are mightier than those who rule the world with their swords.
24. The evil that men do lives after them.
25. All that glitters is not gold.
26. Neither the color nor the design of this cloth appeals to me.
27. Although we know the benefits of exercise, most of us don't know that a brisk after-dinner stroll can help with digestion.
28. Whereas learning about nutrition is not difficult, having the discipline to make wise food choices is often a problem.
29. Even though you can't always control your time, it will help you to set priorities and make a daily To Do list.
30. Unless you are willing to let others control your time, you must learn to politely say no to other people's requests.
31. Change your negative inner dialogue whenever you realize you are being too hard on yourself.
32. So that you feel less stress and enjoy life more, develop your sense of humor.
33. Sit down with a piece of paper and create a plan for solving the problem when you find yourself worrying over one.

Internal use only

34. While there are many relaxation techniques, sitting quietly with your eyes closed and taking a few deep breaths will quickly calm you.
35. Cultivate a positive attitude, because it enables you to enjoy life more.
36. I made an airplane out of stone.
37. I put a piece of cantaloupe underneath the microscope.
38. While fishing in the blue lagoon, I caught a lovely silver fish.
39. They say if you step on a crack, you will break your mother's back.
40. They just had a contest for scariest mask, and I was the wild and daring one who *won* the contest for scariest mask.
41. My voice was raspy, rough, and cracked.
42. I opened my eyes and looked up at the rain, and it dripped in my head and flowed into my brain.
43. They say that once in Zanzibar a boy stuck out his tongue so far that it reached the heavens and touched a star, which burned him rather badly.
44. I joke with the bats and have intimate chats with the cooties who crawl through my hair.
45. The animals snarled and screeched and growled and whinnied and whimpered and hooted and howled and gobbled up the whole ice cream stand.
46. The antlers of a standing moose, as everybody knows, are just the perfect place to hang your wet and drippy clothes.
47. We'll walk with a walk that is measured and slow, and we'll go where the chalk-white arrows go.
48. I am writing these poems from inside a lion, and it's rather dark in here.
49. A piece of sky broke off and fell through the crack in the ceiling right into my soup.
50. The traffic light simply would not turn green, so the people stopped to wait as the traffic rolled and the wind blew cold, and the hour grew dark and late.

4. Identify each of the following sentences as* declarative, interrogative, imperative*, or* exclamatory*.

1. "How beautiful a street is in winter!"
2. "Have the skillet hot and keep it well greased."
3. "We boarded our train with feelings of unbounded relief."
4. "Each cell measured about ten feet by ten and was quite bare within except for a plank bed and a pot of drinking water."
5. "Where were the blackbirds?"
6. "Always obey your parents, when they are present."
7. "The house was so big that there was always a room to hide in, and I had a red pony and a garden where I could wander."
8. "Why does a funeral always sharpen one's sense of humor and rouse one's spirits?"
9. "How can any deny themselves the pleasure of my company?"

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10. "He was exceedingly poor, wearing only a ragged shirt and trousers."
11. "Quietly go in, sit down, look at your man until you have seen him enough, and then go."
12. "I looked tired, but my complexion was good."
13. "She carried her spectacles on a gold chain hung around her neck."
14. "What was the connection between reading and learning?"
15. "Is that all you want?"
16. "Summer people move into the houses that had stood empty, unseen, and unnoticed all winter."
17. "Have you ever considered leaving New York?"
18. "The shacks were built of one thickness of pine planking covered with tarpaper."
19. "She had backed just halfway out of the garage when the engine died."
20. "Don't ask him the time."
21. "The old lady had already risen and placed a saucepan on the fire to prepare the morning milk."
22. "I stopped on a rise and looked back at the valley, which was vanishing in purple haze."
23. "Would I, filled with bookish notions, act in a manner that would make the whites dislike me?"
24. "I visited the spring often in those first years, and had friends there--a frog, a woodcock, and an eel which had churned its way all the way up through the pasture creek to enjoy the luxury of pure water."
25. "If we object to corporal punishment, and I assume we do, on what grounds is this objection based?"

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